

Spreading The Word

A passion for a language saw one man through numerous attempts to make it widely accessible, spanning generations of tech—from the typewriter to the Internet

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When octogenarian Ratilal Chandaria looks back at all the time he spent on realising his project, www.gujaratilexicon.com, which is an online Gujarati lexicon, his pride is mixed with a hint of frustration. "It took me far longer than it should have," he says, referring to the fact that the lexicon is an effort of twenty-odd years.

How did someone who began work in the '80s think about building an online lexicon? Well, he didn't. Ratibhai started out with the hope of increasing the use of the Gujarati language in conjunction with the typewriter.

A Dream Is Born

Born and brought up in Africa, Ratibhai had studied Gujarati as a language in school. The onset of World War II brought him to India, and it was here that he learnt to type in Gujarati on a Remington Gujarati typewriter. Even as a

young boy, Ratilal took pride in his language, and wondered, "Would it be possible to employ technology to help proliferate the use of Gujarati?" He hoped of doing something constructive towards an as-yet-undefined goal.

As Ratibhai neared retirement, he channelled more and more time and energy towards his passion—the Gujarati language. He was in his fifties at this point, and wanted to create a tool through which people would be encouraged to use the language—even if they were living outside India. He spent two years trying to persuade companies to produce electrical typewriters with Gujarati keys.

Golfballs And Fonts

Then in the '60s came the IBM Golfball. This typewriter, instead of the typebar—a small metal arm inside a typewriter with characters at its end—had a pivoting "typeball" that could be changed to enable the use of different fonts in the same document. A Golfball for Devanagari had emerged, and

this gave Ratibhai hope. IBM, however, agreed to make a Gujarati Golfball only if they received an order for a defined number of typewriters, and this Ratibhai couldn't do. Since it was an independent venture, the high cost of tooling—creating independent fonts for the language and then making the keys—was a limiting factor as well.

By the '70s, computers had arrived, and were making headway in offices in the UK where Ratibhai was now based. His goal now was to create something that would enable typing in Gujarati at a computer. Since a working model of an IBM computer with software for the Devanagiri script was being produced, Ratibhai contacted various companies to attempt the same in Gujarati. He also contacted companies that produced Linotype system machines, which were used by newspaper offices for printing, to see if they could produce Gujarati fonts for computers. As before, his attempts were fruitless.

